

UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL

MODEL UNITED NATIONS STUDY GUIDE

Agenda: The Situation in the Middle East

A Multi-Front Regional Crisis — May 2026

"The Security Council shall determine the existence of any threat to the peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression and shall make recommendations, or decide what measures shall be taken... to maintain or restore international peace and security." — UN Charter, Article 39

A NOTE TO DELEGATES

This Background Guide has been prepared by the Academic Directorate to equip all delegates with the factual grounding, legal literacy, and positional awareness needed to engage rigorously in debate. The Middle East crisis of 2026 represents one of the most complex, multi-layered regional emergencies the Security Council has faced since the concurrent crises of the early twenty-first century. Four active wars are burning simultaneously across the region, each with its own actors, legal dimensions, and humanitarian toll — yet all deeply interconnected through ideology, geography, proxy networks, and energy infrastructure.

New delegates are encouraged to: read this guide in full before researching their country's position; take special note of bolded key terms; and consult the QARMA section (Section 6) when drafting resolutions.

SECTION 1: COMMITTEE OVERVIEW & INTRODUCTION

1.1 The UN Security Council — Structure and Mandate

The **United Nations Security Council (UNSC)** is the principal organ of the United Nations responsible for the maintenance of international peace and security, as established under **Chapter V of the UN Charter**. It is composed of **15 member states**: five **Permanent Members (P5)** — the United States, the United Kingdom, France, the Russian Federation, and the People's Republic of China — and **ten non-permanent members** elected by the General Assembly for two-year rotating terms.

Key Powers of the UNSC

Under **Chapter VI**, the Council may call upon parties to settle disputes through negotiation, inquiry, mediation, conciliation, or arbitration. However, it is **Chapter VII** that grants the Council its most powerful tools:

- **Article 39** empowers the Council to determine the existence of any threat to peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression.
- **Article 40** authorizes the Council to call for provisional measures to prevent the aggravation of a situation.
- **Article 41** permits non-military enforcement measures, including sanctions, arms embargoes, and asset freezes.
- **Article 42** authorizes the use of armed force when Article 41 measures are deemed inadequate.

Resolutions passed under Chapter VII are **legally binding** on all UN Member States. This distinguishes Council action from the largely recommendatory resolutions of the General Assembly.

The Veto Power

Each P5 member holds an **absolute veto** over any substantive resolution. A single "No" vote from any permanent member defeats a draft resolution, regardless of how many other members support it. As this guide will discuss in Section 4, the veto has been the central structural obstacle to meaningful UNSC action on the Middle East throughout the twenty-first century.

1.2 Why the Council Has Been Convened — The 2026 Multi-Front Crisis

As of May 2026, the broader Middle East region is simultaneously engulfed in **four active armed conflicts** of varying intensity, each threatening to destabilize not only their immediate theaters but the entire international order:

1. **The 2026 Iran War** — A direct US-Israeli military campaign against Iran's nuclear infrastructure and command apparatus, followed by Iranian retaliatory strikes and a maritime confrontation strangling global energy supply chains.
2. **The 2026 Lebanon War** — A renewed full-spectrum conflict between Israel and Hezbollah that has displaced over one million Lebanese civilians and shattered the fragile UN-brokered ceasefire architecture of Resolution 1701.
3. **The Gaza Enclave Conflict** — An urban warfare campaign now entering its third year, characterized by catastrophic civilian casualties, a complete humanitarian blockade, and the targeted assassination of senior Hamas military commanders.

4. **The Regional Proxy & Maritime Trade War** — A shadow conflict waged through Houthi maritime attacks in the Red Sea, the post-Assad power vacuum in Syria, and an active Iraqi militia corridor funneling weapons and fighters across the region.

The Council is convened in **emergency session** under Rule 3 of its Provisional Rules of Procedure, called by the Secretary-General under **Article 99 of the UN Charter**, which empowers the Secretary-General to bring to the attention of the Council any matter which in their opinion may threaten the maintenance of international peace and security. The overlapping nature of these crises — their shared supply chains of weapons, the same regional powers appearing on multiple fronts, the unified humanitarian emergency affecting tens of millions of civilians — demands a consolidated Council response.

SECTION 2: DEEP DIVE — THE FOUR ACTIVE FRONTS

FRONT 1: The 2026 Iran War

A. Historical Context & Roots

The confrontation between Iran and the Western-Israeli axis has been decades in the making, rooted in a complex interplay of revolutionary ideology, nuclear ambition, and proxy warfare.

The Islamic Revolution (1979) fundamentally reoriented Iran's foreign policy away from its alliance with the United States and toward an explicitly anti-Western, anti-Israeli posture. The revolutionary government's seizure of the US Embassy in Tehran and the 444-day hostage crisis (1979–1981) inaugurated a period of deep mutual hostility that has never fully abated.

Iran's Nuclear Program became the defining international security concern of the 2000s and 2010s. Iran's position has consistently been that its nuclear activities are entirely peaceful and protected under the **Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT)**, to which it is a signatory. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), however, documented a series of undeclared nuclear activities and violations of safeguard agreements across multiple inspection cycles.

The Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), concluded in July 2015 in Vienna, represented a landmark diplomatic achievement: Iran agreed to dramatically curtail its uranium enrichment, reduce its stockpile of enriched uranium, redesign its Arak heavy-water reactor, and accept intrusive IAEA inspections — in exchange for the lifting of multilateral nuclear-related sanctions. The deal was endorsed by UN Security Council **Resolution 2231 (2015)**.

The US Withdrawal (2018) under President Donald Trump shattered the JCPOA framework. The United States' unilateral withdrawal and reimposition of sweeping "maximum pressure" sanctions caused the Iranian economy to contract severely. Iran responded in May 2019 by beginning to systematically exceed JCPOA limits: first on its enriched uranium stockpile, then on enrichment levels, and eventually by reducing cooperation with IAEA inspectors.

By **2021–2022**, negotiations in Vienna to revive a "JCPOA 2.0" repeatedly stalled over Iranian demands for security guarantees, the removal of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) from US terrorist designations, and verification sequencing disputes. By 2023, the IAEA reported that Iran had enriched uranium to 84% purity — one step below weapons-grade (90%) — and had accumulated sufficient fissile material for multiple nuclear devices if enriched further.

The Assassination of Qasem Soleimani (January 2020), the commander of the IRGC's Quds Force, by a US drone strike at Baghdad International Airport dramatically escalated tensions. Iran's retaliatory ballistic missile strikes on US bases in Iraq (which caused traumatic brain injuries to over 100 US personnel) demonstrated both Iran's capability and its willingness to strike directly at US forces.

The Shadow War (2020–2025): The period between 2020 and 2025 was characterized by an escalating shadow war: Israeli cyberattacks on Iranian nuclear facilities (including the Stuxnet successors and the Natanz sabotage of 2021); Iranian drone and missile attacks on Israeli-linked shipping; assassinations of Iranian nuclear scientists attributed to Israeli intelligence; and Iranian proxy operations across Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, and Yemen targeting US and Israeli interests.

By late 2025, intelligence assessments from the US, UK, France, Germany, and Israel had converged on a critical threshold judgment: Iran was estimated to be **weeks, not months, away** from producing its first nuclear weapon. This assessment — disputed by some analysts but accepted by the political leaderships in Washington and Jerusalem — formed the trigger point for military planning.

B. Current State of the Conflict (As of May 2026)

Operation Epic Fury — February 28, 2026

In the pre-dawn hours of February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel jointly launched **Operation Epic Fury**, the most extensive coordinated military strike against Iran since the 1980 Iran-Iraq War.

The operation was executed in three simultaneous waves:

- **Wave One (Suppression of Air Defenses):** US B-2 stealth bombers flying from Diego Garcia and US Air Force F-35s deployed from classified regional airbases, combined with

Israeli F-35I *Adir* aircraft, struck Iran's **S-300 and Russian-supplied Bavar-373** air defense networks at sites around Tehran, Isfahan, Bushehr, and Tabriz.

- **Wave Two (Nuclear Infrastructure):** The primary objective. Fourteen confirmed nuclear sites were targeted, including the **Fordow Fuel Enrichment Plant** (buried 80 meters underground and specifically targeted with US GBU-57 Massive Ordnance Penetrators carried by B-2s), the **Natanz Enrichment Complex**, the **Isfahan Uranium Conversion Facility**, and the **Arak Heavy Water Research Reactor**. The degree of destruction achieved at Fordow — Iran's most hardened site — remains contested, with US officials claiming a 70% degradation of capacity and Iranian officials claiming the facility survived substantially intact.
- **Wave Three (Command & Control):** Targeted strikes on IRGC command and control nodes, the Ministry of Intelligence headquarters in Tehran, and a number of IRGC Aerospace Force missile launch facilities in western and southern Iran.

The Assassination of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei

The most consequential and legally controversial element of Operation Epic Fury was the death of **Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei**, 86, during the strikes on the night of February 28–March 1. Iranian state media initially reported he had been evacuated to a secure location; his death was confirmed by the Iranian government on March 3, 2026, after a period of evident disarray in communications from Tehran. The cause of death was attributed by Iran to injuries sustained in a strike on a command bunker complex southwest of Tehran. The United States and Israel have neither confirmed nor denied that Khamenei was a deliberate target, citing operational security.

Khamenei's death triggered an immediate constitutional crisis. The **Assembly of Experts** was convened in emergency session to appoint a new Supreme Leader. As of May 2026, the internal power struggle within the Iranian establishment remains unresolved, with the clerical establishment and the IRGC each maneuvering for influence over the successor.

Iranian Retaliatory Strikes — March 2026

Iran's response was swift and significant. Beginning on March 5, 2026, Iran launched the following retaliatory actions:

- **Ballistic Missile Barrages:** Over 200 short- and medium-range ballistic missiles were fired at Israeli territory in three waves. Israel's multi-layered air defense network (Iron Dome, David's Sling, and Arrow-3), augmented by US THAAD batteries deployed to the region, intercepted the vast majority. However, several missiles penetrated defenses, causing casualties and infrastructure damage in the Negev and central Israel.
- **Proxy Activation:** Iran activated its full proxy network simultaneously: Hezbollah dramatically escalated rocket and drone attacks on northern Israel (accelerating the Lebanon front); Houthi forces resumed intensive Red Sea missile attacks; and Iraqi Shia militia groups launched a series of drone attacks on US bases in Iraq and the Al-Tanf garrison in Syria.

- **Strait of Hormuz Maritime Toll System:** Iran's most strategically significant retaliation. On March 12, 2026, the IRGC Navy announced the enforcement of a **mandatory maritime toll and inspection regime** at the Strait of Hormuz. Under this regime, all commercial tankers transiting the Strait are required to request IRGC passage authorization, submit to inspection, and pay a transit levy. Vessels carrying cargo to or from Israel, the United States, or states that "cooperated in the aggression" were declared subject to immediate seizure. The IRGC has since seized four tankers, causing global oil prices to spike over 40% from pre-conflict levels.

The Pakistan-Brokered Ceasefire — April 2026

Under intense diplomatic pressure from Pakistan, China, and the UN Secretary-General, a **fragile ceasefire** was brokered in early April 2026, temporarily halting the direct US-Iranian exchange of fire. Pakistan's role as an interlocutor was facilitated by its historical diplomatic relationships with both Iran and the United States. The ceasefire agreement is limited in scope: it suspends active kinetic strikes but does not address the maritime blockade, sanctions, or Iran's nuclear program. Its violation clauses are vague, and it carries no international monitoring mechanism.

The US Naval Blockade — Ongoing

Concurrent with and subsequent to the ceasefire, the United States has deployed a significant naval task force — centered on two carrier strike groups, the USS *Gerald R. Ford* (CVN-78) and USS *Theodore Roosevelt* (CVN-71) — to the Persian Gulf, Arabian Sea, and Red Sea. This constitutes a de facto **naval blockade** of Iran's oil export routes through the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman. Iran has declared the blockade an act of war and has refused to recognize its legality under international law.

Current Status (May 2026):

- The ceasefire holds nominally, but both sides accuse the other of violations.
 - Iran's maritime toll system in the Strait of Hormuz continues to disrupt global shipping; approximately 20% of the world's oil transits the Strait.
 - Iran's nuclear program status is deeply uncertain; IAEA inspectors have been denied access since the outbreak of hostilities.
 - Iran's domestic political situation is volatile, with factional competition for leadership and significant popular unrest in major cities.
 - Diplomatic contact between Iran and the US occurs only through third-party intermediaries (Pakistan, Oman, Switzerland).
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A. Historical Context & Roots

Lebanon's tragedy is, in many ways, the tragedy of a small, fragile state caught between the geopolitical ambitions of far larger actors.

The Emergence of Hezbollah (1982): Hezbollah (*Party of God*) was founded in 1982 with direct Iranian sponsorship following Israel's invasion of Lebanon. Initially a resistance movement against Israeli occupation of southern Lebanon, Hezbollah gradually transformed into one of the most capable non-state armed actors in the world: a political party with parliamentary representation, a social services network, and a military wing armed with a sophisticated arsenal estimated at over 150,000 rockets and missiles by 2024.

The 2006 War and Resolution 1701: The 34-day war of July–August 2006 between Israel and Hezbollah ended with the adoption of **UN Security Council Resolution 1701**, which called for a full cessation of hostilities, the deployment of Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) and an enlarged **UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL)** to southern Lebanon, and the withdrawal of Israeli forces. Resolution 1701 prohibited armed groups other than the LAF and UNIFIL from operating in southern Lebanon. Hezbollah never disarmed and never withdrew from the south; Israeli military presence in disputed areas continued intermittently. The resolution's core disarmament provisions were never implemented, creating a state of frozen conflict.

The October 2023 Border Escalation: Following the Hamas attacks of October 7, 2023 and Israel's military response in Gaza, Hezbollah opened a "support front" in solidarity with Gaza, launching daily rocket, anti-tank missile, and drone attacks against northern Israel, while Israeli forces conducted intensive airstrikes on Hezbollah positions in southern Lebanon. This low-intensity but sustained exchange lasted for months, displacing approximately 60,000–80,000 Israeli civilians from communities near the northern border and a comparable number of Lebanese civilians.

The September–November 2024 Escalation: In September 2024, Israel dramatically escalated its campaign against Hezbollah. The "**pager attack**" — an intelligence operation that caused thousands of Hezbollah-linked communication devices to simultaneously explode across Lebanon — was attributed to Israeli intelligence. Hezbollah Secretary-General Hassan Nasrallah was killed in an Israeli airstrike on Hezbollah's headquarters in the southern suburbs of Beirut (the *Dahieh*) on September 27, 2024. Israel launched a ground incursion into southern Lebanon in October 2024.

The November 2024 Ceasefire: A US and French-brokered 60-day ceasefire came into effect in late November 2024, calling for Israeli withdrawal and Hezbollah's pullback north of the Litani River. The ceasefire repeatedly broke down and was extended; its most recent iteration was a **45-**

day extension agreed in early 2026, which has since been heavily and consistently violated by both parties.

B. Current State of the Conflict (As of May 2026)

Collapse of the 45-Day Truce Extension

The 45-day truce extension, which was brokered with US and French facilitation in early 2026, has effectively collapsed. Both Israel and the remnants of Hezbollah's leadership structure (reconstituted under new leadership following Nasrallah's death) accuse the other of systematic violations:

- **Israeli side:** Israel has continued intermittent airstrikes on what it characterizes as Hezbollah weapons depots and resupply convoys in the Bekaa Valley and around the Beirut-Damascus highway. Israel maintains a residual ground presence in several Lebanese border villages it has not fully withdrawn from, citing the inadequacy of LAF deployment and continued Hezbollah presence in the south.
- **Hezbollah side:** Hezbollah and affiliated groups continue to fire rockets and anti-tank missiles at Israeli positions and communities. Drone operations — including armed UAVs equipped with explosives and reconnaissance drones — have become the dominant tactical medium, replacing the mass rocket salvos of earlier periods.

Humanitarian Crisis

The civilian toll is catastrophic:

- **Over 1 million Lebanese civilians** have been displaced from their homes, with the highest concentrations in southern Lebanon, the southern suburbs of Beirut, and parts of the Bekaa Valley. This represents approximately 20% of Lebanon's total population.
- Lebanon's already collapsed healthcare infrastructure — a country that was already in economic freefall before the current conflict — is overwhelmed. Hospitals in Tyre, Sidon, and southern Beirut are operating at well over capacity.
- **UNIFIL** (approximately 10,000 troops from 50 nations) remains deployed in southern Lebanon but has been effectively constrained. Multiple UNIFIL positions have been struck by fire (Israeli and Hezbollah-attributed), and several troop-contributing nations have threatened to withdraw their contingents if conditions for safe operation cannot be guaranteed.
- International humanitarian access to southern Lebanon is severely restricted. The UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) has declared a Level 3 emergency — the UN system's highest — for Lebanon.

Strategic Dynamics

- Israel's stated war aim in Lebanon is the permanent removal of Hezbollah's military infrastructure from all territory south of the Litani River and the enforcement of Resolution 1701.
 - Hezbollah's reconstituted leadership, operating under significant organizational stress after the loss of Nasrallah and other senior figures, has shifted to a more decentralized command structure and asymmetric tactics.
 - France, the US, and the Arab League have all called for an immediate full ceasefire and the implementation of Resolution 1701, but without a credible enforcement mechanism.
 - Lebanon's government and the Lebanese Armed Forces are caught in the impossible position of lacking both the military capacity and the political will to forcibly confront Hezbollah.
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FRONT 3: The Gaza Enclave Conflict

A. Historical Context & Roots

The Origins of the Gaza Strip's Political Status

The Gaza Strip — a 365-square-kilometer territory on the Mediterranean coast — has been at the epicenter of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict since the mid-twentieth century. Following the Arab-Israeli War of 1948 (*the Nakba* — "catastrophe" — in Palestinian memory), Gaza came under Egyptian administration. Israel captured the territory in the 1967 Six-Day War, occupying it along with the West Bank and Sinai Peninsula.

The Oslo Process and Its Collapse: The Oslo Accords of 1993 established the **Palestinian Authority (PA)** as an interim self-governing body and envisaged a negotiated two-state settlement within five years. Oslo's failure to produce a final status agreement, combined with the expansion of Israeli settlements in the West Bank, deepened Palestinian disillusionment with the peace process.

Hamas's Rise and the 2007 Blockade: Hamas (*Harakat al-Muqawama al-Islamiyya* — Islamic Resistance Movement) won Palestinian Legislative Council elections in 2006, forming a government rejected by the US, EU, and Israel. Following violent clashes with Fatah forces, Hamas seized full control of Gaza in June 2007. Israel and Egypt imposed a comprehensive land, sea, and air blockade on Gaza, citing security concerns and Hamas's refusal to recognize Israel. The blockade has been in effect — with varying degrees of stringency — ever since, and has been repeatedly criticized by UN bodies, human rights organizations, and international courts as constituting collective punishment under international humanitarian law.

The October 7, 2023 Hamas Attack: On October 7, 2023, Hamas and affiliated groups conducted the largest attack on Israeli territory since the 1948 war: approximately 3,000 militants breached the Gaza perimeter fence at multiple points, killing approximately 1,200 Israeli civilians and soldiers and abducting approximately 250 people as hostages. The attack was characterized by widespread atrocities against civilian populations in kibbutzim and at a music festival near Re'im.

Israel's Cabinet declared a state of war and launched **Operation Iron Swords**, beginning with intensive airstrikes and followed by a major ground offensive that began in October 2023.

B. Current State of the Conflict (As of May 2026)

Transition to Targeted Urban Tracking

By early 2026, Israel's military campaign in Gaza has evolved significantly from the initial wholesale aerial bombardment and mass ground maneuvers of late 2023 and 2024. The IDF has shifted to what it characterizes as "**targeted urban tracking**" — a campaign of precise strikes, intelligence-driven raids, and methodical clearance operations in the increasingly destroyed urban landscape of northern, central, and southern Gaza.

Key operational features of this phase include:

- **Tunnel System Destruction:** The IDF has claimed to have destroyed or flooded a substantial portion of Hamas's underground tunnel network (the "Metro") using a combination of engineering units, flooding operations, and precision munitions.
- **Intelligence-Driven Raids:** Small IDF units, guided by real-time intelligence from UAVs, human intelligence assets, and signals intelligence, conduct targeted raids to kill or capture Hamas military commanders and operatives.
- **Population Concentration:** The ongoing military operation has pushed the majority of Gaza's approximately 2.1 million inhabitants into an ever-shrinking area in and around Rafah and the southern coastal strip, creating extraordinary population density in areas with virtually no functioning civilian infrastructure.

Humanitarian Catastrophe

The humanitarian situation in Gaza as of May 2026 represents one of the gravest crises of the twenty-first century:

- The UN has repeatedly warned of **famine conditions**, with the **Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC)** assessing that the entire population of Gaza is experiencing **Crisis** (IPC Phase 3) or worse levels of food insecurity, with a substantial portion in **Emergency** (Phase 4) or **Catastrophic/Famine** (Phase 5) conditions.

- **UNSC Resolution 2417 (2018)** explicitly links the use of starvation as a method of warfare to war crimes under international humanitarian law. UN Special Rapporteurs have raised specific allegations in this regard regarding Gaza.
- Medical infrastructure has been catastrophically degraded. The World Health Organization (WHO) has documented the destruction or effective closure of the overwhelming majority of Gaza's hospitals, with Kamal Adwan Hospital in northern Gaza and portions of the European Gaza Hospital in Khan Younis among the few facilities providing any significant medical care.
- Water and sanitation systems have collapsed, causing the spread of epidemic disease, including outbreaks of hepatitis and acute watery diarrhea, particularly among children.
- Over 50,000 Palestinians have been killed since October 2023, with the UN estimating that a substantial proportion — contested by Israel — are civilians, including a very high proportion of women and children.
- Approximately 85% of the population has been displaced at least once; a significant percentage has been displaced multiple times.

The Assassination of Izz al-Din al-Haddad

A critical recent development with immediate bearing on the Council's deliberations: the assassination of **Izz al-Din al-Haddad**, the commander of the **Qassam Brigades** (Hamass's military wing), in a targeted IDF strike in late April 2026. Al-Haddad had emerged as the senior Qassam Brigades commander in Gaza following the deaths of previous commanders. His elimination represents a significant tactical achievement for Israel's campaign against Hamass's military leadership but has simultaneously:

- Complicated any nascent negotiations over hostage release and ceasefire, removing a potential interlocutor with command authority over Gaza-based forces.
- Triggered a Qassam Brigades statement vowing intensified operations, raising concerns about retaliatory attacks in both Gaza and against Israeli targets elsewhere.
- Deepened the governance vacuum in Gaza, where Hamass's political and administrative structures have been severely degraded, raising acute questions about who — if anyone — exercises effective civilian authority and who can engage in any future political process.

Hostage Situation

As of May 2026, an estimated 50–70 of the original approximately 250 hostages taken on October 7, 2023, are believed to still be alive and held in Gaza, according to Israeli intelligence assessments. Negotiations for their release — mediated through Qatar, Egypt, and the CIA — have repeatedly stalled, and the assassination of al-Haddad has further disrupted the communication channels through which such negotiations were previously conducted.

FRONT 4: The Regional Proxy & Maritime Trade War

A. Historical Context & Roots

No analysis of the 2026 Middle East crisis can be complete without understanding the "**Axis of Resistance**" — the informal Iranian-led network of state and non-state actors aligned against Israel, the United States, and their regional partners. This network includes Hezbollah in Lebanon, Hamas in Gaza, the Houthis (Ansar Allah) in Yemen, various Shia militia groups in Iraq operating under the umbrella of the **Popular Mobilization Forces (PMF/Hashd al-Sha'abi)**, and Iranian-aligned factions in Syria.

The Houthi Movement (Ansar Allah): The Houthis are a Zaydi Shia Islamist movement that emerged from northern Yemen's Sa'dah governorate in the 1990s. After years of conflict with the Yemeni government, the Houthis seized the capital, Sana'a, in 2014–2015, triggering a Saudi-led military intervention. A decade of civil war has left Yemen as one of the world's worst humanitarian disasters, with the Houthis controlling most populated areas of the country's northwest.

The Houthi-Red Sea Campaign (October 2023 onward): Beginning in October 2023, in declared solidarity with Gaza, the Houthis launched a sustained campaign of drone and missile attacks against commercial shipping in the Red Sea, the Gulf of Aden, and the Bab el-Mandeb strait — one of the world's most critical maritime chokepoints, through which approximately 15% of global maritime trade passes annually.

Syria's Post-Assad Collapse: The Assad regime, which had survived a devastating civil war (2011–present) through the military support of Russia and Iran, collapsed in December 2024 following a rapid offensive by Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) and allied rebel factions from Idlib. Bashar al-Assad fled to Russia. Syria entered a period of profound political fragmentation, with HTS-led transitional governance in Aleppo and Damascus, Kurdish SDF control of the northeast, Turkish-backed factions in the northwest border regions, Israeli-occupied areas of southwestern Syria, and US forces remaining at the Al-Tanf garrison.

B. Current State of the Conflict (As of May 2026)

Houthi Maritime Operations — Red Sea

Despite sustained US and UK airstrikes on Houthi military infrastructure in Yemen (Operation Poseidon Archer and subsequent operations), the Houthis have demonstrated considerable resilience and continued operational capacity. As of May 2026:

- The Houthis continue to launch periodic anti-ship ballistic missile (ASBM) and drone attacks against commercial vessels in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, targeting vessels they

characterize as linked to Israel, the US, or the UK.

- The majority of major international shipping lines have rerouted cargo away from the Red Sea and around the Cape of Good Hope, adding 10–14 days to voyage times and significantly increasing global shipping costs and inflationary pressures on consumer goods.
- The **US-led Operation Prosperity Guardian**, a multinational naval coalition tasked with protecting commercial shipping in the Red Sea, has succeeded in intercepting a significant proportion of Houthi projectiles but has been unable to eliminate the threat entirely.
- The Houthis have demonstrated an ability to adapt their tactics, including the use of **USVs (Unmanned Surface Vehicles/waterborne drones)** in addition to aerial drones and ballistic missiles.
- Yemen's humanitarian situation, already catastrophic before the Houthi campaign escalated, has further deteriorated.

Syria — The Post-Assad Power Vacuum

Syria's political landscape in May 2026 is extraordinarily fragmented:

- **HTS-led Transitional Governance** in Damascus and major western cities is attempting to establish legitimate state structures while facing significant international scrutiny given HTS's origins as Jabhat al-Nusra, formerly al-Qaeda's Syrian affiliate. HTS has taken steps to distance itself from its jihadist past, but Western governments remain wary.
- **Israeli Operations in Western Syria:** Following Assad's fall, Israel conducted extensive airstrikes to destroy residual Syrian Arab Army weapons stockpiles — particularly long-range missiles and chemical weapons precursors — and established a forward military presence in the buffer zone of the Golan Heights and areas beyond the 1974 Disengagement Line. Israel has conducted dozens of airstrikes on HTS and Iranian-linked infrastructure in southern Syria.
- **Iranian Influence Disruption:** The fall of Assad dramatically severed the primary Iranian ground corridor for weapons supply to Hezbollah through Syria. Iran has sought alternative resupply routes (maritime, through Iraq), but the efficiency of this corridor has been substantially degraded.
- **US Forces at Al-Tanf:** The US garrison at Al-Tanf in southeastern Syria — at the Syria-Iraq-Jordan border triangle — continues to serve as a strategic position blocking the land corridor between Iran and its proxies in Iraq and Syria/Lebanon.

Iraqi Militias — The Operational Transit Corridor

Iran-aligned militias within Iraq's Popular Mobilization Forces (PMF) continue to serve as a critical node in the Iranian proxy network:

- Several PMF factions — including Kata'ib Hezbollah, Asa'ib Ahl al-Haq, and the Badr Organization — have continued to facilitate weapons transit and provide operational

support to the broader Axis of Resistance.

- These groups have launched periodic drone attacks on US forces in Iraq and on the Al-Tanf garrison in Syria, maintaining pressure on the American military presence in the region.
 - The Iraqi government, caught between its strategic and economic relationship with the United States and the deep institutional penetration of the PMF into its security forces and political structure, has been unable or unwilling to effectively restrain these factions.
 - The post-Operation Epic Fury environment has heightened internal Iraqi political tensions, with significant popular demonstrations in Baghdad both condemning the US-Israeli strikes on Iran and demanding the expulsion of US forces from Iraqi territory.
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SECTION 3: LEGAL FRAMEWORKS & INTERNATIONAL LAW

The 2026 Middle East crisis presents exceptionally difficult questions of international law across multiple legal regimes. Delegates must understand the relevant legal frameworks and be prepared to apply them in resolution drafting.

3.1 The UN Charter

Article 2(4) — The Prohibition on the Use of Force

Article 2(4) is the cornerstone of the post-World War II international legal order:

"All Members shall refrain in their international relations from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state, or in any other manner inconsistent with the Purposes of the United Nations."

Application to the Current Crisis:

- **Operation Epic Fury** constitutes the most direct application: an armed attack by the United States and Israel against the sovereign territory of Iran, a UN Member State, without Security Council authorization. The US and Israel have justified this under Article 51 (see below). Iran and the majority of UN Member States view it as a clear violation of Article 2(4).
- **Israeli operations in Lebanon and Gaza** raise Article 2(4) questions, particularly given the scale and duration of military operations in what Israel terms non-state actor territory (Gaza) and the sovereign territory of Lebanon.
- **Iranian maritime enforcement** in the Strait of Hormuz — physically interdicting vessels and imposing a toll — arguably violates the freedom of navigation rights of third-party states.

- **Houthi attacks on commercial shipping** similarly engage Article 2(4) to the extent they target vessels of states not party to the Yemen conflict.

Article 51 — The Right of Self-Defense

Article 51 provides the most important exception to the prohibition on the use of force:

"Nothing in the present Charter shall impair the inherent right of individual or collective self-defence if an armed attack occurs against a Member of the United Nations, until the Security Council has taken the measures necessary to maintain international peace and security."

Key Legal Debates:

- **Anticipatory Self-Defense:** The text of Article 51 specifies self-defense "if an armed attack occurs." However, a significant body of international legal opinion — developed particularly in relation to counterterrorism — recognizes a right of **anticipatory self-defense** against an imminent attack. The US and Israel have argued that Iran's near-nuclear status constituted an imminent threat justifying pre-emptive action. Critics argue this interpretation stretches Article 51 beyond recognition and could license aggressive wars by any state claiming an adversary poses a future threat.
- **Necessity and Proportionality:** Even if a right of self-defense exists, customary international law requires that force used in self-defense be **necessary** (no reasonable alternative) and **proportional** to the threat. The destruction of Iran's nuclear infrastructure, the degradation of its air defense network, and the killing of its Supreme Leader all raise serious questions about proportionality relative to any claimed defensive necessity.
- **Collective Self-Defense:** Under Article 51, states may exercise collective self-defense on behalf of a state that has been attacked. Gulf states and others considering alignment with US-Israeli positions must carefully assess whether Article 51 justifies their involvement or support.

3.2 International Humanitarian Law (IHL) / The Geneva Conventions

International Humanitarian Law — also known as the **Law of Armed Conflict (LOAC)** — governs the conduct of hostilities once armed conflict has commenced. The core IHL principles applicable to the current crisis are:

Distinction

The Principle of Distinction requires that parties to a conflict at all times distinguish between **civilian persons and combatants**, and between **civilian objects and military objectives**. Only military objectives may be deliberately attacked.

Application: The extensive destruction of civilian infrastructure in Gaza — including hospitals, water treatment facilities, flour mills, and UN facilities — has generated intense legal scrutiny. Israel maintains that it targets only military objectives and that Hamas's use of civilian infrastructure as military positions (tunnels beneath hospitals, command nodes in residential areas) transfers responsibility for civilian harm to Hamas. Critics and UN Special Rapporteurs dispute both the factual premise and the legal conclusion, arguing that the scale and pattern of destruction reflects a failure to uphold the principle of distinction.

Proportionality

The Principle of Proportionality prohibits attacks expected to cause incidental civilian casualties or damage to civilian objects that would be **excessive in relation to the concrete and direct military advantage anticipated**.

Application: Proportionality analysis is fact-specific and highly contested. In the Lebanon context, Israeli airstrikes on densely populated areas of Beirut — conducted to kill individual Hezbollah commanders — present classic proportionality dilemmas: the military advantage of eliminating a specific commander must be weighed against the expected civilian harm, including deaths and destruction of civilian infrastructure. Both the US strikes on Iran and Israeli operations in Gaza and Lebanon are subject to proportionality analysis under IHL.

Military Necessity

The Principle of Military Necessity permits only those measures that are actually necessary to accomplish a legitimate military objective and that are not otherwise prohibited by IHL. It is sometimes invoked to justify actions that might otherwise appear disproportionate, but it is not a blanket license for any action that might conceivably advance military goals.

Blockades and Siege Warfare

The Gaza Blockade and US Naval Blockade of Iran both engage specific IHL rules on blockades:

- A blockade is lawful under IHL if it is applied impartially, does not cut off access to goods indispensable to the survival of the civilian population, and is not intended to starve the civilian population.
- The **San Remo Manual on International Law Applicable to Armed Conflicts at Sea (1994)**, while not a binding treaty, is widely regarded as authoritative on these questions. It permits blockades that are effective and do not prevent access to humanitarian supplies.
- The complete prevention of humanitarian aid to Gaza over extended periods has been characterized by multiple UN bodies as a potential violation of IHL, specifically the prohibition on the use of starvation as a method of warfare (codified in **Additional Protocol I, Article 54**, and reflected in **UNSC Resolution 2417**).

Targeted Killings

The targeted killing of **Supreme Leader Khamenei** and **Qassam Brigades commander al-Haddad** raise specific IHL questions about the lawfulness of targeted killings under the **law of armed conflict**. Under IHL, a person who is a member of an organized armed group or who "directly participates in hostilities" is a lawful target. The Supreme Leader's status as the commander-in-chief of Iran's armed forces makes him a lawful military target under IHL (notwithstanding the diplomatic and political implications). The broader question of whether targeted killing programs comply with IHL's requirements of precaution and proportionality remains deeply contested.

3.3 Maritime Law — UNCLOS and the Laws of the Sea

The Legal Status of the Strait of Hormuz

The **Strait of Hormuz** — connecting the Persian Gulf to the Arabian Sea — is approximately 33 nautical miles wide at its narrowest point. It is the world's most strategically important maritime chokepoint.

Under **UNCLOS (the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea, 1982)**, the Strait of Hormuz is subject to the regime of **Transit Passage** (Part III, Articles 37–44), which applies to straits used for international navigation between one part of the high seas and another. Transit passage is a right of all ships and aircraft — including warships — to navigate continuously and expeditiously through such straits. It cannot be suspended by the bordering state.

Iran's Position: Iran (which is not a party to UNCLOS, having declined to ratify it) maintains that the Strait falls within its territorial sea and that it has the right to control passage under its own domestic legislation and the principle of innocent passage. Iran's maritime toll system is premised on this claimed authority.

The International Community's Position: The overwhelming majority of states — including the US, UK, EU member states, China, and most Gulf states — regard Iran's maritime toll system as a violation of the customary international law right of transit passage, which they argue applies regardless of UNCLOS ratification status.

The Legal Debate: The right of transit passage is codified in UNCLOS but is also widely regarded as reflecting customary international law. Iran's enforcement of a toll and inspection regime — and its seizure of commercial vessels — constitutes, in the view of most international legal scholars, a serious violation of international law that threatens the foundational principle of freedom of navigation.

The Red Sea and Houthi Operations

The Red Sea — specifically the Bab el-Mandeb Strait — is similarly a critical international

waterway governed by the law of the sea. The Houthis' attacks on commercial shipping in international waters violate the prohibition on piracy under **UNCLOS Article 101** if they meet the definition of piracy (committed for private ends), or constitute unlawful acts of violence against ships under the **Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts Against the Safety of Maritime Navigation (SUA Convention, 1988)**.

The Houthis characterize their attacks as acts of war against states supporting Israel in Gaza, not piracy. The legal characterization matters because it affects which legal regime — and which enforcement mechanisms — apply.

SECTION 4: THE UNITED NATIONS' ROLE & PAST ACTIONS

4.1 UN Bodies and Mandates in the Region

UNIFIL — United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon

Established by **UNSC Resolution 425 (1978)** and significantly expanded and reinforced by **UNSC Resolution 1701 (2006)**, UNIFIL is currently the largest UN peacekeeping mission by contingent-contributing nation diversity. Its mandate includes:

- Confirming the withdrawal of Israeli forces from southern Lebanon.
- Assisting the Lebanese government in ensuring the return of its effective authority in the south.
- Ensuring that its area of operations is not used for hostile activities.
- Supporting the Lebanese Armed Forces.

UNIFIL's structural weakness has been apparent throughout the current conflict: it has a **non-enforcement mandate** and cannot physically interpose itself between belligerent forces. It can monitor, report, and provide a physical presence that *in theory* raises the cost of violations — but it cannot stop an Israeli airstrike or a Hezbollah rocket launch. Multiple UNIFIL positions have been struck, injuring peacekeepers, and the force's utility has been severely questioned.

UNSCOL/UNSCO — UN Special Coordinator for Lebanon / for the Middle East Peace Process

The **UN Special Coordinator for Lebanon** and the **UN Special Coordinator for the Middle East Peace Process (UNSCO)** provide political coordination and good-offices functions. Both offices have been engaged in intensive diplomatic consultations since the escalation began, but their leverage is limited by the lack of political will among the P5 to endorse meaningful enforcement measures.

UN Humanitarian Coordination — OCHA, UNRWA, WFP, WHO

- **OCHA (Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs):** Coordinates the overall humanitarian response across the region. Has declared Level 3 emergencies for both Gaza and Lebanon.
 - **UNRWA (United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees):** The primary UN agency providing humanitarian services in Gaza, including food distribution, medical care, and education. UNRWA has faced an existential institutional crisis following allegations — vigorously contested — that a number of its staff members were involved in or had knowledge of the October 7, 2023 attacks. Several major donor states temporarily suspended funding; some have reinstated it. UNRWA's operational capacity in Gaza has been severely compromised by the destruction of its facilities (multiple UNRWA facilities have been struck by Israeli fire) and the deaths of over 200 UNRWA staff members in Gaza.
 - **WFP (World Food Programme):** Has issued repeated warnings of famine conditions in Gaza and food security deterioration in Lebanon and Yemen.
 - **WHO (World Health Organization):** Has documented the systematic destruction of medical infrastructure in Gaza and the severe strain on Lebanon's health system.
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4.2 The P5 Veto Deadlock

The single most significant structural feature shaping — and distorting — the UNSC's response to the Middle East crisis is the **veto power of the Permanent Members**.

The Pattern of Deadlock

Since October 2023, the Security Council has been effectively paralyzed on meaningful action regarding the Gaza conflict and related crises. The pattern has been consistent:

- Draft resolutions calling for ceasefires, humanitarian corridors, or investigations into potential violations of international law have been vetoed by the **United States** on the grounds that they were unbalanced, did not acknowledge Israel's right to self-defense, or were premature given ongoing negotiations.
- Draft resolutions proposed by or supported by Russia and/or China, calling for immediate ceasefires without conditions, have been accepted by the US only in watered-down form or vetoed by the US on procedural or substantive grounds.
- The US has also vetoed resolutions seeking independent international investigations into the conduct of hostilities in Gaza.
- Russia and China have used the veto to block resolutions that would impose sanctions or other measures against Iran.

Post-Operation Epic Fury Deadlock

The launching of Operation Epic Fury has deepened the deadlock along predictable lines:

- **Russia and China** have introduced draft resolutions condemning Operation Epic Fury as a violation of Article 2(4) and the UN Charter, demanding an immediate halt to hostilities, and calling for an international investigation into the killing of Khamenei. Both resolutions were vetoed by the **United States** (and in one instance, the UK).
- **The United States** introduced a draft resolution calling for Iran to immediately cease its maritime toll enforcement and to allow unrestricted passage through the Strait of Hormuz, backed by the implicit threat of Article 42 enforcement measures. This resolution was vetoed by **Russia and China**.
- France and the United Kingdom have attempted to broker compromise language that would address both the maritime crisis and call for a return to diplomatic channels on the nuclear question, but these efforts have not yet produced a resolution capable of surviving the P5 veto calculus.

This deadlock illustrates a fundamental tension in the post-1945 international order: the P5 veto, designed to prevent the Security Council from being used against the great powers, has also made it effectively impossible for the Council to act decisively in conflicts where P5 members have strong opposing interests. The result is that the primary legal mechanism for the maintenance of international peace and security — the Security Council — is structurally incapacitated at precisely the moment when the world most needs it to function.

SECTION 5: GUIDE TO BLOC POSITIONS

The following section provides a structured overview of key actors' foreign policy positions, interests, and typical alliances. This is intended to assist delegates in researching their countries' positions and understanding the diplomatic landscape.

5.1 The United States

Core Interests: Maintaining its alliance commitments to Israel; preventing nuclear proliferation in the Middle East; ensuring freedom of navigation in the Persian Gulf, Red Sea, and Strait of Hormuz; protecting the US dollar's role as the global reserve currency (heavily linked to oil pricing in USD); and preventing the emergence of an Iran-led regional order hostile to US interests.

Position on Key Conflicts:

- **Iran:** Characterizes Operation Epic Fury as a lawful act of collective self-defense under Article 51, aimed at preventing Iran from obtaining nuclear weapons. Maintains the naval

blockade as a legitimate pressure tool. Seeks a return to negotiations on a comprehensive nuclear deal from a position of Iranian weakness.

- **Gaza:** Continues to provide military assistance to Israel while calling, with increasing urgency, for enhanced humanitarian access. Has vetoed multiple ceasefire resolutions but has also applied behind-the-scenes pressure on Israel to allow more humanitarian aid. Seeks the release of Israeli-American hostages held in Gaza.
- **Lebanon:** Supports the implementation of UNSC Resolution 1701 and has been involved in ceasefire mediation. Concerned about Hezbollah's long-range precision missile arsenal.
- **Yemen/Red Sea:** Leads the naval coalition protecting Red Sea shipping. Has conducted extensive airstrikes on Houthi military infrastructure in Yemen.

Typical Alliances in the Council: United Kingdom, France (on most issues, though with more nuance on Gaza). Israel is not a Council member but is the central partner of US policy.

5.2 Israel

Note: Israel is not currently a member of the UN Security Council. However, it is the central actor in three of the four active fronts and its policy positions directly shape the Council's deliberations.

Core Interests: Preventing an Iranian nuclear weapon (existential priority); eliminating Hamas's military and governing capacity in Gaza; ensuring that Hezbollah cannot threaten Israeli communities from Lebanese territory; maintaining strategic freedom of action across the region; and securing the release of remaining hostages.

Position on Key Conflicts: Israel characterizes all its military operations as lawful acts of self-defense under Article 51, triggered by the October 7, 2023 attack and subsequent threats from Iran and its proxies. It rejects the application of occupation law to Gaza, characterizes Hamas as a terrorist organization with no standing under IHL, and argues that Hezbollah's systematic violations of Resolution 1701 justified its military response in Lebanon.

5.3 The Islamic Republic of Iran

Core Interests: Survival of the Islamic Republic system; prevention of regime change; advancing its nuclear program (at minimum, preserving a nuclear hedge); maintaining and expanding its regional influence through the Axis of Resistance proxy network; and lifting of economic sanctions.

Position on Key Conflicts:

- **The Iran War:** Characterizes Operation Epic Fury as a flagrant act of aggression in violation of Article 2(4) and international law. Demands international condemnation, reparations, and the complete withdrawal of US forces from the Persian Gulf region. The maritime toll regime is characterized as a legitimate exercise of sovereign rights in self-defense.
- **Gaza/Lebanon/Yemen:** Provides political and material support to Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Houthis; characterizes these as legitimate resistance movements against occupation and aggression, protected under international law's right to self-determination.

Domestic Political Context: The death of Khamenei and the ongoing succession struggle create significant uncertainty about Iran's foreign policy decision-making. Hardliners within the IRGC who favor continued confrontation are in tension with pragmatists who may see a negotiated settlement as necessary for economic survival and political stability.

5.4 Palestine

Note: Palestine holds **Non-Member Observer State status** at the UN (since 2012, following General Assembly Resolution 67/19), which allows it to participate in General Assembly debates but not to vote or hold Council membership.

Core Interests: Ending the military campaign in Gaza and securing a lasting ceasefire; unrestricted humanitarian access; accountability for alleged violations of international law; and the long-term goal of establishing an independent Palestinian state on the 1967 borders with East Jerusalem as its capital.

Position: Palestine calls for an immediate and unconditional ceasefire, the lifting of the blockade, and the withdrawal of Israeli forces from Gaza. Palestine has submitted referrals to the International Criminal Court and supported the South Africa-led genocide case at the International Court of Justice (ICJ). The ICJ's preliminary rulings in early 2024, indicating that the rights of Palestinians to be protected from genocide were plausible and ordering Israel to take measures to prevent genocidal acts, represent a significant legal development Palestine leverages in all multilateral forums.

5.5 Lebanon

Note: Lebanon is similarly a directly affected non-Council member state; Lebanon's government is represented in UN debates as a victim and affected party.

Core Interests: Ending the armed conflict in Lebanon; the full implementation of Resolution 1701 (withdrawal of all non-LAF armed forces from southern Lebanon); reconstruction of devastated civilian infrastructure; preserving Lebanese sovereignty and preventing the country's total state collapse; and avoiding being drawn into a wider regional war.

Domestic Political Complexity: Lebanon's government has historically been unable to adopt a unified position that explicitly distances itself from Hezbollah, given Hezbollah's deep integration into Lebanese political and institutional life. The current government faces the impossible task of simultaneously calling for peace and lacking the capacity to enforce it.

5.6 The Gulf States — Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar

Saudi Arabia:

- The Kingdom has undergone a significant strategic evolution. The Saudi-Iranian rapprochement agreement brokered by China in March 2023 normalized diplomatic relations between the two regional powers. However, Operation Epic Fury and Iran's maritime toll regime have severely strained this normalization.
- Saudi Arabia's primary interest is regime stability and economic development (Vision 2030). The oil price spike caused by the Strait of Hormuz crisis has paradoxically benefited Saudi oil revenues in the short term but created geopolitical pressure and economic uncertainty.
- Saudi Arabia has not publicly endorsed Operation Epic Fury but has called for an immediate end to hostilities and a return to diplomatic channels.

United Arab Emirates:

- The UAE has followed a pragmatic foreign policy course, maintaining economic ties with Iran while deepening security cooperation with the US and pursuing normalization with Israel under the Abraham Accords (2020).
- The maritime crisis in the Strait of Hormuz is of acute concern to the UAE, whose entire economic model depends on the free flow of trade through the Gulf.

Qatar:

- Qatar hosts the largest US military base in the Middle East (Al-Udeid Air Base) while simultaneously maintaining diplomatic relations with Hamas, Iran, and Turkey — positioning itself as the indispensable mediator.
 - Qatar has been the primary channel for hostage negotiations between Israel and Hamas. The assassination of al-Haddad has complicated Qatar's mediation role.
 - Qatar's **Al Jazeera** network serves as the primary Arabic-language media voice for Palestinian perspectives and has been a source of significant diplomatic friction with other Gulf states and Israel.
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The ten non-permanent members of the Security Council — drawn from across Africa, Latin America, Asia, and Europe — represent a diverse range of positions, but several consistent themes emerge from the non-aligned and neutral bloc:

Shared Priorities:

- **Humanitarian Access:** The broadest consensus exists on the need for unrestricted humanitarian access to Gaza, Lebanon, and Yemen. Even states that are reluctant to endorse ceasefire language can often be brought on board for humanitarian access provisions.
- **International Law:** Many non-permanent members emphasize the need for accountability and the application of international law — including IHL — to all parties, without double standards.
- **Multilateralism:** Deep concern about the precedent set by Operation Epic Fury for the rules-based international order and the prohibition on the use of force.

European Non-Permanent Members:

- Typically seek a balance between expressing solidarity with Israel's right to self-defense and urging compliance with IHL. More willing than the US to criticize specific Israeli military operations. Strong emphasis on humanitarian access, a two-state solution, and the JCPOA diplomatic framework.

African and Latin American Members:

- Tend to emphasize solidarity with the Palestinian cause through a decolonization and self-determination framework. Strong advocates for ceasefire language and international accountability mechanisms. Often invoke the "**Uniting for Peace**" Resolution (UNGA Resolution 377) when the Council is deadlocked.

SECTION 6: QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ADDRESS (QARMA)

A well-drafted Security Council resolution must be operational and actionable — not merely aspirational. The following questions represent the core operational gaps that delegates must address in any resolution on the situation in the Middle East. Resolutions that fail to address these questions risk being procedurally weak, unimplementable, or ineffective.

QARMA 1 — Humanitarian Access in Gaza: *What specific, enforceable mechanisms will the resolution establish to guarantee the immediate, sustained, and unrestricted delivery of humanitarian aid — food, medicine, water, and fuel — to the civilian population of Gaza, and who will bear responsibility for monitoring compliance and reporting violations to the Council?*

QARMA 2 — Ceasefire Monitoring and Enforcement in Lebanon: *How will the resolution strengthen the monitoring and enforcement capacity of UNIFIL and the Lebanese Armed Forces in southern Lebanon to ensure that the terms of UNSC Resolution 1701 are actually implemented, and what consequences will the resolution specify for parties that violate a renewed ceasefire?*

QARMA 3 — Strait of Hormuz and Freedom of Navigation: *What concrete measures will the resolution propose to restore freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, including the cessation of Iran's maritime toll enforcement regime and the US naval blockade, and what international monitoring mechanism will be established to protect the right of innocent passage for vessels of all states?*

QARMA 4 — Red Sea Maritime Security: *How will the resolution address the Houthi threat to commercial shipping in the Red Sea, and will it authorize, endorse, or establish a multilateral naval protection force — and if so, under what mandate, command structure, and legal basis?*

QARMA 5 — Iran's Nuclear Program: *What diplomatic pathway will the resolution establish toward the resumption of IAEA inspections of Iran's nuclear facilities, and how will it balance calls for verified de-escalation of Iran's nuclear activities with the removal of the conditions that Iran cites as having driven its nuclear expansion?*

QARMA 6 — Gaza Governance and the "Day After": *Following the elimination of Hamas's senior military leadership, what interim governance, security, and civil administration arrangements will the resolution propose for Gaza to prevent a complete governance vacuum, and how will it ensure civilian protection in the interim period?*

QARMA 7 — Hostage Release: *What specific role — if any — will the Security Council play in facilitating negotiations for the release of remaining hostages held in Gaza, and how will the resolution structure any link between hostage release, ceasefire terms, and humanitarian access?*

QARMA 8 — Regional Escalation Prevention: *What early-warning, communication, and de-escalation mechanisms will the resolution establish to prevent any of the four active fronts from triggering a broader regional war, including specific measures to reduce the risk of direct military confrontation between the United States and Iran and to prevent the Syrian and Iraqi theaters from becoming additional flashpoints?*

APPENDIX: KEY TERMS GLOSSARY

Term	Definition
JCPOA	Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action — the 2015 nuclear agreement between Iran and the P5+1
IRGC	Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps — Iran's elite ideological military force
IHL	International Humanitarian Law — the laws of armed conflict
UNCLOS	UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (1982)
UNIFIL	UN Interim Force in Lebanon
PMF/Hashd al-Sha'abi	Popular Mobilization Forces — umbrella of Iranian-aligned Iraqi militias
HTS	Hayat Tahrir al-Sham — Syrian rebel group controlling Damascus and northwestern Syria
IPC	Integrated Food Security Phase Classification — global standard for measuring food insecurity severity
OCHA	Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
UNRWA	UN Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees
Transit Passage	UNCLOS regime granting all ships/aircraft the right to navigate through international straits
Proportionality	IHL principle: civilian harm may not be excessive relative to military advantage anticipated
Distinction	IHL principle: parties must distinguish between combatants and civilians
Article 51	UN Charter provision establishing the right of individual and collective self-defense
Chapter VII	UN Charter chapter granting the Security Council enforcement powers, including use of force
P5	Five Permanent UNSC Members: US, UK, France, Russia, China
QARMA	Questions a Resolution Must Address — standard MUN framework for resolution drafting

APPENDIX: KEY UN RESOLUTIONS FOR REFERENCE

Resolution	Year	Subject
UNSC Res. 425	1978	Established UNIFIL; called for Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon
UNSC Res. 1701	2006	2006 Lebanon War ceasefire; reinforced UNIFIL; prohibited non-LAF armed forces in south Lebanon
UNSC Res. 2231	2015	Endorsed the JCPOA; established monitoring mechanism
UNSC Res. 2417	2018	Prohibits use of starvation as method of warfare; links food insecurity to conflict
UNGA Res. 67/19	2012	Granted Palestine Non-Member Observer State status
UNGA Res. 377	1950	"Uniting for Peace" — allows UNGA to convene when UNSC deadlocked
UNSC Res. 2722	2024	Called for ceasefire in Gaza (vetoed by US in earlier iterations)

This Study Guide was prepared by the Academic Directorate for educational purposes in the context of a Model United Nations simulation. All references to events of 2026 are simulated for the purposes of the exercise. Delegates are encouraged to conduct additional independent research using primary sources including the United Nations Digital Library (undocs.org), the ICRC website ([icrc.org](https://www.icrc.org)), and established international news organizations.

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